the indigenous population. A few Chinese merchants and traders have also migrated to the Islands since the late 1800s.

In the 1970s, tension between the two major ethnic groups—Fijians and Indians—was the dent Fiji, an Indian diplomat, Surendra Singh, had warned that the island nation's ethnic Indians would be badly treated. For India, Fiji is not just another country, Tiwari told Gandhi. It is a little bit of India in the far-off South Pacific region and strategically important to India.

Indians first entered Fiji in 1879 as indentured labourers mostly shipped out of Uttar Pradesh and Bihar to work on sugarcane plantations owned by the British colonists. In 1916, when British plantation owners stopped sending demands for labourers, sponsored immigration virtually ceased, but about 40,000 to 50,000 Indians entered the Fiji colony in phases, thereafter. After indentured labour was abolished, most of these Indians chose to remain in Fiji and were settled by the British on two islands. In 1959, when the first census was conducted, the total population of Fiji was 3,87,646, out of whom 1,91,328 were Indians. The Indian birth rate in 1959 was 46.46 per 1,000, the Fijian 36.36, the European 30.30 and the Chinese 37.01.

Gandhi and Tiwari were discussing Fiji's demography when R&AW Chief A.K. Verma walked in with a red file. The coup had been led by Colonel Sitiveni Rabuka, an ethnic Fijian military officer who wanted Indians to be thrown out of Fiji. The ethnic Indians called Rabuka a snake—a betrayer of trust and faith. Verma informed Gandhi that this was going to be a long and bloody war.

The R&AW had turned eighteen that year, the age of adulthood. The men and women of the agency had had hits and misses